

text’ to start the conversion process. Perhaps its best feature is the error correction method. It highlights all suspect words, and the probable matches are listed in a drop-down box. A Merge button lets you combine adjacent words by removing the space between them. Once you are finished with correcting the document, you can save it in either the Word or the txt formats.

SimpleOCR comes bundled with a 14-day trial version of CharacTell, a handwriting recognition software, priced at \$79.95 (Rs 3,678). Consider SimpleOCR only if you need basic-level OCR for free.

- + Free; easy to correct errors
- Very poor accuracy

And the winner is...

ABBYY FineReader is the undisputed champion. The only software that could give it a run for its money was OmniPage. And the newspaper-clip test helped us decide between the two, since an OCR software that faithfully reproduces a newspaper clip in its entirety has to be the winner.

In terms of accuracy, OmniPage and FineReader are pretty close; but FineReader wins on sheer versatility and features.

Summing up....

Choosing the OCR software for your needs is pretty easy. There are the heavyweights, the middleweights and the

lightweights—and which is which is amply demonstrated by our tests. Generally, the better the software, the more expensive it is, without much exception. Occasional users might try SimpleOCR or Cuneiform; business and other high-end users should certainly consider investing in FineReader or OmniPage; and the other software are for those who lie in the middle of the user spectrum.

Finally, remember that once you have an OCR software installed, you might come up with lots of uses for it! 📄

RAM MOHAN RAO

ram_mohan@thinkdigit.com

MOULY ARUN PRABHU

mouly_arunprabhu@thinkdigit.com

CATEGORY		OCR SOFTWARE					
Name		Cuneiform Pro 6.0	ABBYY FineReader 6.0	OmniPage Pro 12.0	Readiris Pro 8	Typereader 6.0 Professional	SimpleOCR 3.1
FEATURES (20%)	Ease of reading from scanner (1-3)	1	3	3	3	3	1
	Digital Camera Support	✗	✓	✗	✗	✗	✗
	Auto rotate	✗	✓	✓	✓	✗	✗
	Auto Processing	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
	Deskew	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
	Several input formats	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✗
	Batch Processing	✓	✓	✓	✗	✓	✗
	Save as .doc	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
	Save as .html	✗	✓	✓	✓	✗	✗
	Save as .pdf	✗	✓	✓	✓	✗	✗
	Save as .xls	✗	✓	✓	✗	✓	✗
	ODMA support	✗	✗	✓	✗	✗	✗
	Good suspect-word checker)	✓	✓	✓	✗	✓	✓
	Learning/training capability	✗	✓	✓	✓	✗	✗
	Layout selection options (1-3)	1	3	3	3	3	2
EASE OF USE (10%)	Full-featured text editor	✓	✓	✓	✗	✓	✓
	Business Cards	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗
	Total score for features	60	93	92	70	72	39
	Easy Icons	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
	Ease of navigation (1-3)	2	3	3	2	2	1
ACCURACY (70 %)(SCORES OUT OF 100)	Wizards (1-3)	1	3	3	1	2	1
	Help (1-3)	1	3	3	2	2	2
	Online Help	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✗
	Total score for Ease of use	63	100	100	70	80	57
	Inkjet Printout	62	84	87	66	75	43
OVERALL SCORE	Photocopy of Inkjet document	65	100	86	86	86	55
	Dot-matrix Printout	71	100	100	100	100	57
	Typewritten Document	46	84	98	90	86	62
	Excel Sheet	35	82	62	47	7	13
	Fax Printout	71	100	100	100	100	43
CONTACT	Magazine page with white on black	0	94	59	0	0	0
	Newspaper Scan	0	100	65	65	28	0
	Page with several symbols	18	53	50	53	53	28
	Total score for Accuracy	47	93	84	77	70	37
	FEATURES (20%)	12.066	18.6	18.4	13	14.4	7.734
VENDOR	EASE OF USE (10%)	6.333	10	10	7	8	5.667
	ACCURACY (70%)	32.62	64.855	58.94	53.62	48.825	26.005
	Overall Grade	📄	📄	📄	📄	📄	📄
	Vendor	OCR.COM	NetSpider	HCL Infosystems	I.R.I.S.	ExperVision	SimpleOCR
	E-mail	sales@ocr.com	sales@netspiderindia.com	seigell@hclinsys.com	info@irisusa.com	marketing@expervision.com	Info@simpleocr.com
PRICE	Web site	www.ocr.com	www.netspiderindia.com	www.hclinfosystems.com	www.irislink.com	www.expervision.com	www.simpleocr.com
	Price (Rs)	5,392	13,800	27,600	18,492	11,454	0